

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Awakening: Life from Death
Evil & Theodicy - The Problem with God
Eastertide 6

June 1st, 2025



Gerardo Dottori – Brani di Futurismo del Maestro dell'Aeropittura

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Hymn Improvisation

Meditation on *O filii et filiae*

EASTER HYMN (Anthony Giamanco) and Improvisation

VRUECHTEN (Robert Lind) and Improvisation

DUKE STREET (Leonardo Antonio Di Chiara) and Improvisation

Short Prelude and Fugue in D minor (ascribed to Bach)

Praeludium in A-moll (Gustav Merkel) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

We live in a world of surprise and beauty,
a world of complexity and color,
a world of challenge and delight,
a world of anxiety and alleluias.

We are lifted and fed by the wonder in it,
humbled and laid low by its tragic realities.
In the interwoven moments of its blessing and blight,
we make our lives.

May we, in the spaces between sorrow and delight,
in the moments between harsh reality and beauty,
in the fear that lies in wait between truth and possibility,
learn the art of making light,
that we might shine with peace
and live with hope.

*Together on this journey,
we share what comes
with dignity, grace, and love,
as we follow
the Way of Jesus.*

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

O for a World

AZMON

O for a world where everyone respects each other's ways,
Where love is lived and all is done with justice and with praise.

O for a world where goods are shared and misery relieved,
Where truth is spoken, children spared, equality achieved.

We welcome one world family and struggle with each choice
That opens us to unity and gives our vision voice.

The poor are rich, the weak are strong, the foolish ones are wise.
Tell all who mourn: outcasts belong, who perishes will rise.

O for a world preparing for God's glorious reign of peace,
Where time and tears will be no more, and all but love will cease.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Holy One,
in the living of this day,
may we find the courage to let go of our fears,
accept the challenges before us
and open ourselves
to the still, small voice
we know to be grounded in holiness.

May our souls, O God,
be filled with the awe of who
we are called to be.

*As those who seek after the light,
help us to follow the One
who is the light.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

"Hallelujah, Hear Our Prayer!" from *Prayers In A Time Of Plague*
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, Assistant Conductor

NICK STRIMPLE

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

*Eternal Spirit, Earth Maker, Pain-Bearer, Life-Giver,
Source of all that is and that shall be,
Father and Mother of us all,
Loving God, in whom is heaven:
The hallowing of your name echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed by the peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done by all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom sustain our hope and come on earth.
With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.*

*In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure, spare us.
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.
For you reign in the glory of the power that is love, now and forever.
Amen.*

[pmoore/newzealandprayerbook]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

In the center of the whirlwind
lies the eye of the storm.
Still. Open. Calm.

Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries,
no storms,
only peace.

As we find our way in life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember where we come from
and, as the need arises,
and it will,
may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it is home,
knowing it is you, O God.

*As those who walk with the wind,
we journey on.*

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from the Gospel of Luke, Chapter 24

Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

For these words of the ancients we say,
Thanks be to God!

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

*After the silence, you are invited to come forward to bring your written prayers
and to light candles to signify the prayers of your hearts and pray for the life of the world.*

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts

Holy God, Creator of us all,
you have formed us to live full
and beautiful lives with you.
You challenge us to take risks,
to go beyond ourselves
and to reach out to others.

Jesus, the Holy One,
knew the reality of human life.
Jesus knew that to open ourselves up
is to risk being vulnerable,
that to love is to risk being hurt,
and that to live fully is to confront our mortality.

And yet we know that we feel drawn to this presence,
not to be shielded from heartache
or the pain of human life,
but to heal and inspire us
and to gently redirect us
until we see the world as open and ever changing
and love it with your gracious love.

Together, help us to understand
that we can make changes in our lives
and live more fully from our hearts and our minds.
Help us to enter the risks we encounter with you,
help us to love the people around us with you,
and help us to have the kind of compassion
that can be turned into action.

*Help us to listen,
help us to hear again,
remind us that with you
we can do all things.*

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Priere"
Dr. Fahad Siadat, Soloist

MAHMOUD TABRIZI-ZADEH

*"Heart, O my heart, my ravaged heart, my sunken light. I sigh, I roar, I cry, my desolate heart. I call out
"God, O God, this night is yours." I entreat the cosmos. I call out to the heavens. O God, my God, I cry."*

Sermon

Evil and Theodicy – The Problem with God

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"23rd Psalm"
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, Assistant Conductor

BOBBY MCFERRIN

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

Holy One,
our goodness comes from your goodness.
We revere your dream for us
and for our world.
Help us to support your ways
in all we do as we strive to follow
the Way of Jesus.

Strengthen us to resist selfishness,
shield us from believing that holding tight
to all we have, will keep us from life's brokenness.

*Remind us each day, Eternal One,
that we are held by you
through all space and time,
and that what we do with
our precious lives
will outlast anything
we might possess.*

We ask this in the name of the One we follow.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

As we leave this place,
may we remember
it is always a long walk to Emmaus.
And may we also remember that meeting the holy
happens along the way
not at the end,
and telling the truth about what has happened
sends us to the journey that we await.

*So we thank you, O God, for the people who walk –
for their courage and their feet,
for the way their spirits
catch fire on the long miles.*

And we thank you, O God, for the hearts
that are changed in everyone
who breaks bread with them
along the way.

*Help us, O God, to hear their story
in all the world
and when something breaks,
may we recognize you as the one who
brings the Good News.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

“More Waters Rising”
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, Assistant Conductor

SARA TOMLINSON, arr. SAUNDER CHOI

*Hymn for the Journey

Be Now My Vision

SLANE

Be now my vision, O God of my heart;
nothing surpasses the love you impart –
You my best thought, by day or by night,
waking or sleeping, your presence my light.

Be now my wisdom, and be my true word;
ever within me, my soul is assured;
Mother and Father, you are both to me,
now and forever your child I will be.

Riches I need not, nor life's empty praise,
you, my inheritance, now and always;
You and you only are first in my heart,
great God, my treasure, may we never part.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Short Fugue in D minor - Reprise (ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Inside The Music

"Today's music parallels our examination of how we reconcile the presence of an all pervading and inherently good God with the existence of evil. It begins with a prayer to God in times of hardship, exploring how we seek nearness with the divine when we feel distance. This is followed by a Sufi work by Mahmoud Tabrizi-Zadeh, the kamanchi player made famous by his contributions on Peter Gabriel's soundtrack to the film "The Last Temptation of Christ". In the Sufi tradition, that longing for nearness *is* the connection we seek to God, finding the Presence in the heartache.

Bobby McFerrin's reinterpretation of Psalm 23 celebrating both the maternal and divine feminine expresses our comfort in the knowledge of God's constant Presence. The service ends with a declaration of our own resilience in the face of hardship, bolstered by our knowledge that we stand amidst grace, emanating both from God and our collective spirit as a community." -Dr. Fahad Siadat

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